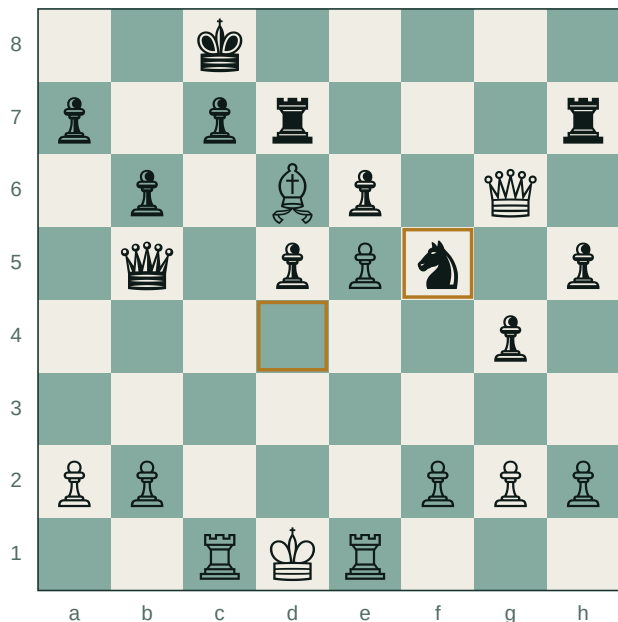


Queenside attacks: White, move 25

Queenside attacks

White to move



Previous move: 24...Nf5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25. Qe8+ Kb7 26. Rxc7+ Rxc7 27. Qxb5

25.Qe8+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. From e8 it attacks king on c8 and rook on d7. Recorded reply: **25...Kb7**.

26.Rxc7+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. From c7 it attacks king on b7 and rook on d7. Recorded reply: **26...Rxc7**.

27.Qxb5 The queen captures the queen on b5.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 19 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -1 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The board's left half is not inherently safe. Queen checks and rook entries can make a queenside king as vulnerable as a kingside one.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An attack on the queenside can target a castled king, a vulnerable pawn, or trapped pieces. Files and entry squares matter more than simply advancing flank pawns.

HOW TO LOOK

Locate the critical target and which pawn or piece move opens a route toward it. Check whether central counterplay interrupts the plan.

The defending king is on c8. Absolute pin: pawn on c7.